handsome win in the Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD) election in 2022.

At outreach exercises like street-corner meetings, it is weaving a narrative of its victimhood at the hands of the BJP. Playing poor David to a Goliath suits AAP's politics well. Kejriwal's wife Sunita, who had stepped in to campaign following his arrest, is doing the same regularly in Haryana where the party will vie for all the assembly seats soon.

Its leaders, like ministers and MPs and MLAs, have been holding forth on TV, and its vast online support base is trying to discredit the 'scam' story from various angles. "They want to stop Delhi government's work, and take Kejriwal out of the picture. Because they cannot fight us politically," says AAP legislator Durgesh Pathak. "But even then, our good work for Delhi has not stopped."

Education minister Atishi has inaugurated multiple government school buildings this month. The state government has been regularly writing to the bureaucracy as well as the Lieutenant Governor's office highlighting issues. The idea is to keep the show running, much to the chagrin of the BJP. "He (Kejriwal) is so intoxicated with a craving for power that he will not leave the CM's chair," says BJP MP Bansuri Swaraj who claims there is a "policy paralysis" in the capital with Kejriwal behind bars.

THE ELECTORAL BOND TWIST

Providing substantial ammunition to AAP's counter-attack are the revelations from the electoral bonds. On March 14 this year, a week before Kejriwal was arrested, details of donors and recipients of the erstwhile electoral bonds were made public following an SC directive. The disclosures revealed that P. Sarath Chandra Reddy's Aurobindo Pharma, an accused in the liquor scam, donated a substantial amount to political parties, primarily the BJP. Specifically, Aurobindo Pharma purchased electoral bonds worth Rs 52 crore between April 2021 and November 2023, with Rs 34.5 crore going to the BJP (other parties that benefitted include the YSRCP and the TDP). The company bought Rs 5 crore worth of bonds in favour of the BJP on November 15, 2022, just five days after Sarath's arrest. After he turned approver in June 2023, it made an additional donation of Rs 25 crore to the BJP in November that year (Sarath has since been pardoned by the court). "This proves that it is the BJP which has taken the bribe in the liquor scam probe," alleges Sanjay Singh, AAP's Rajya Sabha MP, who was himself arrested in the case last year and was only released on bail in March this year.

INTERVIEW

'POLITICS IS A LONG GAME...WE WILL EMERGE 1,000 TIMES STRONGER'

In a freewheeling interview with **AVISHEK G. DASTIDAR**, *AAP leader and former deputy chief minister* **MANISH SISODIA**, *out on bail after 17 months, defends the liquor policy and claims it is a manufactured controversy by the BJP. He also says AAP is set to win again in Delhi. Excerpts:*

Q. In hindsight, what could you have done differently with the liquor policy?

It was a good policy for the people of Delhi. You must understand, Delhi had a new policy every year. A policy was made in 2003-04, which was tweaked every year. When we came in 2015, we did some major tweaks, and the government benefitted in terms of revenue. Based on that learning, we brought this new policy in 2021-22. This was a new model, which we could have tweaked slowly, year by year. That is what would have happened.

Q. What kind of tweaks?

Like, for instance, we allowed discounts. But when we saw the ground reality, that because of discounts the competition was too cut-throat, we limited it. That's how it is. If you see someone taking a wrong advantage of some point in the policy, then you tweak it and fence it. This was a policy that would have benefitted Delhiites in a big way. Today, a large section in the city get their liquor from Gurgaon or Noida. There is a professional network that smuggles it in and sells it here. Ultimately, the Delhi government loses in terms of revenue; the people stand to lose too.

Q. But you took the policy down.

They (BJP) maligned it, made it controversial, created a situation where no officer was willing to implement it. So, to keep things running, we had to revert to the old policy.

THE SAVING GRACE FOR AAP HAS BEEN THE INVESTIGATING AGENCIES' FAILURE TO TRACE THE PROCEEDS OF THE CRIME